



“We could afford it. But we didn't want to give in to his every whim. We would like to run the show.”

Sriparna Basu, 40, B-SCHOOL CONSULTANT, DELHI

It was hardly a one-off. Earlier this year, Mumbai police picked up 50 teens for spraying graffiti on cars and smashing up property at the dead of night, just because they were “bored”. The parents were clueless about their children's activities.

They would probably have put in more effort if only they knew about the latest research on adolescent brain. High-powered Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) studies done at the University of California, Los Angeles, US have shown adolescent behaviours so familiar to parents—emotional outbursts, reckless risk-taking and rule-breaking—occur largely because their brains lack the facilities for a mature and responsible behaviour (*See graphic The Teen Brain*). According to the Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences, 2004, teenage behaviour is not just a matter of wilful pigheadedness to drive parents crazy.

In May, Kolkata girl, Anwesa Bera, 15, wanted to spend more time with her friends. Her parents wanted her to spend more time with her books. In the wake of a war of wills, Anwesa took the ultimate revenge on her parents by hanging herself from the ceiling with her mother's sari. She's one of the 4,000 teens who committed

suicide last year in the country, reminds city psychiatrist, Dr Rima Mukherjee. “India's economic success has resulted in escalating aspirations,” she says. “Kids who've been given too much too soon feel they can achieve anything and want instant gratification. When they don't, they get impatient and frustrated at once, she adds” A NIMHANS study on suicide in 2006 found that 57 per cent of youth suicides are sudden acts of frustration.

Time was when Indian parents controlled children with an iron rod. Obedience was expected and no was a household word. But in a world where families spend “quality time” at the mall, those norms are going the way of the dodo. By every measure, parents are bending over backwards to please their children. Over 50 per cent want their children to move ahead in life, reported a Kantar Media study last month, whatever it may cost. Indian parents spend about Rs 364 crore a year on their children, says a 2006 Cartoon Network survey on 9,000 respondents. Children want more because there's so much more to get today: about 70 per cent nag parents for things (“Everybody around me has one”); 84 per cent

The power of No: She and her husband love to treat their four-year-old son Sumantra to clothes and toys, but are trying to be reasonable. “It's tough to say no, when you can say yes,” she says. Recently she let Sumantra play with a stuffed rocking horse at a toy store. He wanted to ride it home, but they said no.